

STUDY SHEET — PARASHAH KI TAVO

Deuteronomy 26:1–29:9 · Haftarah: Isaiah 60:1–22 · Gospel: Matthew 4:13–24 · The Frame

§0. Observation round (order-safeguard)

This round fixes the production order: first observe, then the axes as an open question, then read off the center of gravity, and only then the thread. The directional test is the horizon, not the starting point.

0.1 Blind observation

The parashah opens with the firstfruits (26:1–11): when you come into the land, take the first of all the fruit, put it in a basket, go to the place He chooses, and speak a confession — ‘a Syrian ready to perish was my father’ (arami oved avi): we went down to Egypt, became a people, were oppressed, cried out, and the LORD brought us out with a strong hand into this land of milk and honey; and now I bring the first. And you shall rejoice in every good thing. Then the tithe confession (26:12–15), and a mutual declaration (26:16–19): you have said the LORD is your God, and the LORD has said you are His own people. Then the stones at Shechem, with all this Torah, and Gerizim/Ebal with twelve curses over mostly hidden sins, each answered with ‘Amen’ (27). Then the great blessing and curse (28). And then (29:1–9): you have seen it all — the signs and wonders — ‘yet the LORD hath not given you an heart to perceive, and eyes to see, and ears to hear, unto this day’ (29:4).

Recurring tension: everywhere the human is called to say and to do (the firstfruits confession, ‘I have hearkened’, ‘you have said’, the ‘Amen’, obey-and-be-blessed) — and then 29:4 says that the heart to truly understand this is no achievement of one’s own, but is given.

0.2 The four axes as an open question

Axis	What the text brings up	Weight
Will	Dominant in volume: the whole parashah is covenant response — bring the first (26:2), confess (26:5–10), remember, obey, rejoice (26:11), answer ‘Amen’ (27:15–26).	Bearing.
Source	Equally bearing: everything is received — the land, the fruit, being a people — down to the heart to understand (29:4). The status ‘his own people’ (am segulah) is pronounced by God (26:18).	Bearing — meets Will in thankfulness.
Coherence	Present but not the core: the twelve curses touch hidden sins (27:15–26) — wholeness, no gap between inside and outside; and blessing/curse is a coherence of consequences (28).	Supporting; honest as second pole.
Trajectory	‘When you come into the land’ (26:1); the forty years (29:5); ‘unto this day’ (29:4).	Thin.
Reactivity	Weak; not foregrounded.	Marginal.

0.3 Read-off center of gravity

Read off, not chosen: it is about the covenant response as thankful remembrance — serving out of received abundance. The two bearing axes are Source (all is gift, down to the heart) and Will (confessing, remembering, obeying, rejoicing), and they meet in thankfulness. The firstfruits are the paradigm; 28:47 is the negative reverse (joyless service = the root of the curse); and 29:4 is the floor: even the heart to understand this is given.

0.4 Framing test

Did this come from the observation? Yes — the frame of the parashah (firstfruits at the front, 29:4 at the end) plus the diagnosis in 28:47 steer together toward the thankful, remembering heart.

Two things honestly. One: the axes (Source–Will) are the same as at Re’eh, and I must check that I am not imposing that template. Tested: the content is different and read from this text — Re’eh landed on ‘not in your own eyes but before His face’;

Ki Tavo lands on thankful remembrance (arami oved avi, 28:47, 29:4). That two Deuteronomy parashot both turn on will-as-response is the nature of Deuteronomy, not import; the hinges here are Ki Tavo's own.

Two: there is a real alternative reading I do not paper over — the twelve curses over hidden sins (27:15–26) and the blessing/curse consequences pull toward Coherence (wholeness, no gap between hidden and open). That pole is real in 27–28. But the frame and the diagnosis (28:47) press harder on the remembering heart than on integrity, so that is where it lands — on Source–Will, with the Coherence pull honestly named.

§1. The thread

Bringing the first back — serving out of what you received. Everything in Ki Tavo is gift: the land, the fruit, being a people, down to the heart to understand (29:4). And precisely therefore the response is not an achievement but thankfulness: you bring the first back, with the story of grace on your lips, and you rejoice. Joyless, forgetful service (28:47) is the root of the curse; thankful remembrance the root of the blessing.

§2. Peshat per block

2.1 The firstfruits (26:1–11)

When you come into the land, take the first of all the fruit in a basket, go to the chosen place, and give it to the priest. 26:5–10 — the confession 'a Syrian ready to perish was my father': Egypt, growing into a people, oppression, crying out, the exodus with a strong hand, the land — and now the first. 'Rejoice in every good thing' (26:11).

2.2 The tithe confession (26:12–15)

The third-year tithe for Levite, stranger, fatherless and widow; 'I have hearkened to the voice of the LORD' (26:14). Obedience as an audible answer.

2.3 The mutual declaration (26:16–19)

You have declared this day that the LORD is your God; and the LORD has declared that you are His own people (am segulah), set high above the nations.

2.4 The stones and the curses (27)

On entry, great stones plastered with lime, inscribed with all this Torah; an altar. Gerizim/Ebal; twelve curses — mostly over hidden sins — each answered with 'Amen'.

2.5 Blessing and curse (28)

The blessings on obedience; the long, swelling curse on disobedience; and the key: 'because thou servedst not the LORD thy God with joyfulness and with gladness of heart, for the abundance of all things' (28:47).

2.6 'No heart to perceive' (29:1–9)

You have seen it all — the signs, the wonders, the forty years — 'yet the LORD hath not given you an heart to perceive, and eyes to see, and ears to hear, unto this day' (29:4). Keep the words of this covenant and do them.

2.7 Haftarah — Isaiah 60:1–22

'Arise, shine; for thy light is come, and the glory of the LORD is risen upon thee' (60:1). The light rises upon you and the nations come to that light — received light that is reflected back.

2.8 Gospel — Matthew 4:13–24

Yeshua in Capernaum, in 'Galilee of the nations': 'the people which sat in darkness saw great light' (4:16, citing Isa. 9). The calling of the first disciples (leaving the nets, following), preaching and healing.

§3. The two bearing axes and their relation

3.1 Source — all is gift

The land, the fruit, being a people: nothing is earned. Even the heart to understand is given or withheld (29:4), and the status 'his own people' is pronounced by God (26:18). The human receives before he brings anything back.

3.2 Will — the thankful response

And precisely therefore the response is no self-achievement but thankfulness: bring the first, confess the story of grace, remember, obey, rejoice, answer 'Amen'. The will is truly addressed — but as an answer, not as a source.

3.3 The relation — thankful remembrance as hinge

26:5–10 — the firstfruits confession (arami oved avi): you bring the first back with the story of gift on your lips. Receiving and giving back in one act. 28:47 — joyless, forgetful service ‘for the abundance’ is the root of the curse: the gift without the remembering turns. 29:4 — even the heart to understand this is gift; the will is addressed but not autonomous.

Honest limit: this two-axis reading too can tempt to a too-neat synthesis. The safeguard is that the firstfruits (front), 28:47 (mid-curse) and 29:4 (end) carry the figure themselves — not brought by the reader.

§4. Deepening: joy as the test

The parashah makes joy not an atmosphere but a test. Two people can keep exactly the same commandments; the difference lies in 28:47 — with or without gladness, out of remembrance or out of habit. The firstfruits show where the joy comes from: not from what I achieved, but from what I received, told again at every harvest. And 29:4 lays bare the floor: where joy and understanding are absent, that is no failure of technique but a lack of the given heart. The test is thus not ‘do I do enough?’ but ‘do I remember, and do I rejoice in the Giver?’

§5. The directional test as horizon

Beneath all this lies the one question — received or grasped — as the ground. The firstfruits are the received-form: the first back, because all is given. The joyless ‘my own strength has gotten me this’ service (cf. 8:17; 28:47) is the grasped-form. And in the gospel the horizon becomes visible: the light rises (Isa. 60; Matt. 4:16), and the eyes 29:4 still withheld open in Yeshua — the given heart, embodied.

§6. Status table

Status	Item	Note
● Bearing	The firstfruits (26:1–11)	Bring the first of all fruit back to the chosen place, with the confession of grace — the paradigm of serving out of received abundance.
● Bearing	Arami oved avi (26:5)	‘A Syrian ready to perish was my father’ — the whole story of gift (Egypt, exodus, land) on the lips while bringing. Remembrance as the core of the gift.
● Bearing	‘Rejoice in every good thing’ (26:11)	Joy is not a side matter but the form of the thankful response.
● Bearing	You have said / the LORD has said (26:17–18)	Mutual covenant declaration; your confession stands over against His pronouncement about you.
● Bearing	Am segulah (26:18)	The status ‘his own people’ is not earned but pronounced by God.
● Bearing	28:47 — the key	‘Because thou servedst not the LORD with joyfulness and gladness of heart, for the abundance’ — joyless, forgetful service is the root of the curse.
● Bearing	29:4 — the floor	‘The LORD hath not given you an heart to perceive ... unto this day’ — even the heart to understand this is gift, no achievement.
● Bearing	Tithe confession (26:12–15)	‘I have hearkened to the voice of the LORD’ — obedience as an audible answer, the gift shared with Levite, stranger, fatherless, widow.
● Bearing	‘Arise, shine’ (Isa. 60:1)	Haftarah: the light comes upon you (received); you shine by reflecting it

Status	Item	Note
		back — the same receive-and-give structure as the firstfruits.
● Bearing	'A great light' (Matt. 4:16)	Gospel: the people in darkness see a great light — Isaiah fulfilled in Yeshua; the eyes 29:4 still withheld open.
● Suggestive	The basket (teneh, 26:2,4)	Image of bringing the first back; homiletically usable, after the peshat.
● Suggestive	The stones with the Torah (27:2–8)	The Word made visible in the land at entry; suggestive motif of remembrance.
● Suggestive	Milk and honey / the abundance (26:9; 28:47)	The abundance that should have led to joy; links the blessing to the key in 28:47.
● Suggestive	Reflecting light (Isa. 60) → firstfruits	The receive-and-give structure of the light mirrors the bringing of the first; suggestive parallel.
● Suggestive	The eyes that open (29:4 → Matt. 4)	From 'no heart to perceive' to 'a great light'; suggestive-christological line, after the peshat.
● Watch	Do not detach the curse from 28:47	Do not read ch. 28 as bare threat; the root the text itself names is joyless service.
● Watch	The twelve curses (27) not moralistic	They touch precisely hidden sins (wholeness, no gap inside/outside), not merely a conduct list.
● Watch	29:4 not as determinism	Not an arbitrary withholding by God, but dependence on grace; no fatalism.
● Watch	Matt. 4:13–24 not apart from Israel	'Galilee of the nations' (4:15) stays within the covenant; no replacement.
● Confession	Yeshua gives the heart 29:4 withheld	Confessional application: the heart to perceive, the eyes to see, are given in Him — not exegetically compelling.
● Confession	The light that rises (Isa. 60 / Matt. 4:16)	Read confessionally as Yeshua, in whom Isaiah's light rises over the people in darkness.
● Confession	The firstfruits → Christ as firstfruit	Confessional line (cf. 1 Cor. 15:20): He is the firstfruit; what we bring back, we received in Him.
● Confession	Leaving the nets and following (Matt. 4:20)	The received-form embodied: the light rises, and the answer is to let go and follow.

§7. Podcast translation

Core in one sentence: in Ki Tavo you bring the first back because all is gift — and the joy in it is no atmosphere but the test of whether you still remember Who gave it.

Image: the basket with the first fruit, and the story of grace spoken aloud as you set it down — 'a Syrian ready to perish was my father'.

Question to carry: do I serve out of joy over what I received, or out of duty and my own strength — and do I still remember from Whom it comes?

§8. Source accounting

BHS, Deut. 26:1–29:9 — checkpoints: arami oved avi (26:5), am segulah (26:18), 28:47 (joyless service), 29:4 (no heart to perceive).

BHS, Isa. 60:1 ('arise, shine') — checkpoint for the haftarah core.

NA28, Matt. 4:16 (citing Isa. 9:1–2, 'a great light') — checkpoint for the gospel, marked as confessional.

The placement of Matt. 4:13–24 as gospel reading and Isa. 60:1–22 as haftarah: liturgical/redactional given, marked as such.